

30 Jochebed

The mother who hid her baby, set him on the Nile, and was paid to nurse her own son.

Jochebed was a woman of the tribe of Levi, living as a slave in Egypt when Pharaoh ordered every Hebrew baby boy thrown into the Nile. She is named only twice, in family lists, but Exodus 2 tells her story without using her name. She hid her newborn son for three months, then made a small basket, sealed it, and placed him among the reeds. God used her quiet courage to save the child who would become Moses. She was also the mother of Aaron and Miriam, so the leader, the priest and the prophetess of the Exodus all came from her home. Hebrews counts her act as faith.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	<i>Yokheved</i> , perhaps "the LORD is glory" (debated)
<i>Family</i>	Daughter of Levi; wife of Amram, her nephew (Exodus 6:20)
<i>Children</i>	Miriam, Aaron and Moses (Numbers 26:59; 1 Chronicles 6:3)
<i>When</i>	The oppression in Egypt, c. 1526 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
<i>Key places</i>	Egypt, the banks of the Nile
<i>Main passages</i>	Exodus 2:1–10; 6:20; Numbers 26:59
<i>New Testament</i>	Not named. Hebrews 11:23 praises the faith of Moses' parents

"By faith Moses, when he was born, was hid three months of his parents, because they saw he was a proper child; and they were not afraid of the king's commandment."

Hebrews 11:23, KJV

The life of Jochebed

Only Moses' birth can be roughly dated: c. 1526 BC on the early Exodus date, or about 185 years later on the late date. Exodus 2 calls her "a daughter of Levi" and "the child's mother"; her name comes from Exodus 6:20 and Numbers 26:59.

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| In Egypt | ● A daughter of Levi |
| | She is born into the tribe of Levi during Israel's long stay in Egypt. Numbers says her mother bore her to Levi in Egypt. <i>Numbers 26:59</i> |
| In Egypt | ● Marries Amram |
| | She marries Amram, a Levite of the family of Kohath. Exodus notes that she was his father's sister. <i>Exodus 2:1; 6:18, 20</i> |
| Before the decree | ● Mother of Miriam and Aaron |
| | She bears a daughter, Miriam, and a son, Aaron, who is three years older than Moses. <i>Exodus 7:7; Numbers 26:59</i> |
| c. 1526 BC | ● Hides her newborn |
| | Pharaoh has ordered every Hebrew son cast into the river. When she sees her baby is "a goodly child," she hides him for three months. <i>Exodus 1:22-2:2</i> |
| c. 1526 BC | ● The basket in the reeds |
| | When she can hide him no longer, she makes an ark of bulrushes, seals it with slime and pitch, and lays it by the river's brink. His sister watches from a distance. <i>Exodus 2:3-4</i> |
| c. 1526 BC and after | ● Nurses her own son |
| | Pharaoh's daughter finds the child. His sister offers to fetch a Hebrew nurse and brings his mother. She nurses him for wages until he is grown enough to go to the palace. <i>Exodus 2:5-10</i> |

Key activities

Exodus 6:20 says Amram married his father's sister. The later law forbade such marriages (Leviticus 18:12), but this was before that law was given. Some scholars also think the family list in Exodus 6 skips generations.

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- 1 Saw something special in her son.** She saw that he was "a goodly child." Hebrews says both parents saw it and acted in faith. *Exodus 2:2; Hebrews 11:23*
 - 2 Defied the king.** She and Amram hid their son for three months and "were not afraid of the king's commandment." *Exodus 2:2; Hebrews 11:23*
 - 3 Built a little ark.** She took a basket of bulrushes, sealed it with slime and pitch, and laid it among the reeds. *Exodus 2:3*
 - 4 Trusted and waited.** She let go of her son, while his sister stood at a distance to see what would happen. *Exodus 2:3–4*
 - 5 Nursed him for Pharaoh's daughter.** Called by her daughter, she took her own child home and was paid to nurse him. *Exodus 2:7–9*
 - 6 Gave him up a second time.** When the child grew, she brought him to Pharaoh's daughter, who named him Moses. *Exodus 2:10*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jochebed.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:1–10	Her story, told without her name
Exodus 6:20	Amram's wife, "his father's sister," mother of Aaron and Moses
Numbers 26:59	Levi's daughter, mother of Aaron, Moses and Miriam
1 Chronicles 6:3	Her three children listed as Amram's
Echo: Genesis 6–8	Noah, too, is saved in an ark
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:22–28	Hannah gives her weaned son back to God

New Testament

Hebrews 11:23	The faith of Moses' parents (she is not named)
Acts 7:20–21	Moses nourished in his father's house three months
Echo: Matthew 2:13–16	Another king kills baby boys; a family hides a child
Echo: 2 Timothy 1:5	Faith learned from a mother and grandmother

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What practical steps did Jochebed take to protect her son (Exodus 2:2–4)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews calls her actions faith. What makes an ordinary, practical choice an act of faith?
3. *Apply:* Jochebed had to let go of her child twice. What is one thing you need to place in God's hands right now?
4. *Apply:* Her quiet work shaped three leaders. Who are the young people you could invest in this month, and how?